



Before You Sign

A Writer's Guide to Choosing a Publisher You Can Trust

Use this guide to understand your publishing options, evaluate potential partners with confidence, and **ask the right questions before making any commitment.**

Choosing How to Publish Is Its Own Decision

Writing a book is a major accomplishment. Choosing how to publish it is the next important step, and it can feel just as significant as the writing itself.

Today's publishing landscape gives authors more options than ever before. That can be empowering, but it can also make it harder to tell the difference between a credible publishing partner and a company that is simply good at marketing itself. Many websites use similar language, similar promises, and similar success stories, which makes careful evaluation essential.

This guide is designed to help you understand the main publishing paths, identify warning signs and risk factors, and ask informed questions before signing any agreement.

✓ A partner succeeds only when your book succeeds.

! A profit machine has already succeeded the moment your payment clears.

The rest of this guide gives you a practical framework for evaluating publishers, comparing offers, and protecting your interests as an author. Review it before you speak with anyone, and keep it nearby when those conversations begin.

There Are Three Ways to Publish a Book

Traditional publishing. The author pays editing costs, the publisher pays design and production costs while giving author very little say in the results, and the publisher will determine a marketing budget based on the author's efforts to drive sales. If books aren't selling, the publisher's marketing efforts will be minimal, if at all. The author typically earns a royalty of about 10 to 15 percent, and the publisher owns the rights to the book. It is highly selective and usually reached only through a literary agent. Authors who put in the work book after book can improve their contract terms over time, securing more marketing budget and more control over design and marketing angles, though earnings will remain about the same.

Self-publishing. The author pays for and manages everything—editing, design, production, distribution, marketing—and in return keeps all rights and the largest share of any profit. There is no gatekeeping, but also no built-in professional support.

Hybrid publishing sits between the two. The author pays for professional services and keeps 100% of their rights and royalties. In exchange for that investment, the author gains what self-publishing alone cannot provide: experienced editorial, design, and marketing support to develop, package, and bring the book to market, and the counsel of an invested partner at every decision. Full ownership and full control remain with the author throughout. The book is published under a publisher's name—a signal to readers, reviewers, and booksellers that it is a polished, professionally made book—but housed in the author's publishing accounts so they maintain full control. The author carries the investment and reaps all of the rewards.

A real hybrid publisher is selective. It evaluates manuscripts and turns some away. A company that accepts every manuscript just to secure revenue is not a publisher in any meaningful sense but a profit machine that has borrowed the language of publishing.

That selectivity is what gives a publisher's name its meaning. When a publisher puts its imprint on a spine, it vouches for the book to readers, reviewers, and booksellers, making a promise about quality and value, and that endorsement is only worth something if the publisher has been willing to turn books away. Protecting the imprint protects everyone under it. The reputation that opens doors for one book opens them for the next, and every author on the list benefits from a name that still means something.

Done right, hybrid publishing offers the best of both worlds: the selectivity, professional craft, and trusted imprint of traditional publishing paired with the ownership, control, and royalties of self-publishing. The whole question comes down to how a company is built—on partnership or on profit margin.

The Green Flags

WHAT A LEGITIMATE HYBRID PUBLISHER LOOKS LIKE

A trustworthy hybrid publisher shows most or all of the following.

- ✓ **Transparent pricing.** They tell you what things cost in writing and early, before you are emotionally invested. You should never have to work to find out what you will pay.
- ✓ **You keep your rights and your royalties.** A legitimate hybrid publisher leaves you owning your work. Your royalty share sits well above the traditional 10 to 15 percent, often 50 percent or more depending on the distribution/retailer agreements. The book remains yours, lives in your accounts where you have full control of receiving payments directly, zero delays in reporting, and can make changes without waiting on someone else over the long term.
- ✓ **They are selective.** They read your manuscript and evaluate it honestly, then show you the results whether accepting your submission or declining. Sharing the assessment results helps you learn more about the publisher's interests and alignment with your goals, or know what to work on for a revised query that will be more successful next time. Selectivity protects the value of being published by them, ensuring the publisher's brand name is trusted by retailers and readers.
- ✓ **Professional-grade production.** Real editing, professional cover and interior design, and thorough research and development for meta data and sales listings. You can see the standard for yourself in the books they have already published.
- ✓ **Genuine distribution.** Your book is available to order through major retailers and available to bookstores and libraries that wish to stock it, not merely listed on a single website. Distribution leverages the biggest and the best systems—KDP and IngramSpark—rather than work through middleman operations that dilute profit margins and limit access.
- ✓ **Realistic expectations.** They will not promise you the book will sell itself. They will talk honestly about what marketing can and cannot do and what success looks like for a book like yours.
- ✓ **A verifiable track record.** Real authors, real books you can find and hold, and real author testimonials.

The Red Flags

WARNING SIGNS TO TAKE SERIOUSLY

Any one of these is worth pausing over. Several together should stop you.

- ❗ **Vague or hidden pricing.** They will not put numbers in writing. The price shifts between conversations. Fees appear that were never mentioned.
- ❗ **Pressure and urgency.** “This rate is only good until Friday.” Publishing your book is a major decision—a good partner gives you room to make it.
- ❗ **One-size-fits-all packages.** Bundles that discount pricing use cheap, unskilled labor or AI.
- ❗ **Guarantees of success.** Promises of bestseller status, specific sales figures, or your book on shelves in stores nationwide. No one can guarantee sales, and note the difference between a book being available to stores and being stocked by them. The first is normal while the second is something no publisher controls.
- ❗ **No selectivity.** Your manuscript is accepted within hours, with no real evaluation. Flattery is not assessment.
- ❗ **Rights grabs.** Contract language that takes your copyright, or ties up your rights for a long term with no clear way to get them back.
- ❗ **A hollow track record.** Few books, weak cover design, no authors you can find online, or glowing testimonials with no verifiable source.
- ❗ **“Everything included” but nothing itemized.** Be wary of packages that sound comprehensive but never specify what you actually receive.

The Questions to Ask Before You Sign

Put these to any hybrid publisher you are considering, including us. A good publisher will answer all of them readily and in writing.

On Rights and Royalties

- ☐ Do I retain full copyright and ownership of my work?
- ☐ What royalty percentage do I earn, and how is it calculated?

On Cost and What Is Included

- ☐ What is the total cost and what exactly does that cover?
- ☐ Are there any additional or ongoing fees not contained in that figure?
- ☐ What happens if the book needs another round of editing or a design revision?

On the Work Itself

- ☐ What kinds of editing are included and what does each editing type cover?
- ☐ Are your editors, designers, publication and marketing professionals in-house or subbed out?
- ☐ What is your vetting criteria for each specialty role? What does quality control look like?
- ☐ Do I have final approval over the edited text, cover and interior designs, and marketing content?

On Production and Distribution

- ☐ Which formats will be produced?
- ☐ Where will my book be available, and can bookstores and libraries order it?
- ☐ What is a realistic timeline from signed contract to finished book?

On Marketing and Results

- ☐ What marketing is included, and what is my role?
- ☐ What results are realistic for a book like mine?

On Track Record

- ☐ May I see books you have published recently?
- ☐ Where can I review client testimonials?

Reading the Contract

When you reach the contract stage, slow down. Read the whole document privately, not in the room or while on the call. A reputable publisher expects you to take a contract away, read it carefully, and return with questions.

If any terminology is unclear, ask for it to be explained in plain language and in writing.

Always review Terms & Conditions on the publisher's website in addition to the contract, as that is a gray area where the publisher can override language in the contract.

Above all, notice how the publisher responds to your scrutiny. A good one welcomes it. Reluctance to let you examine a contract carefully or efforts to rush you for a decision is, itself, an answer.

A Final Word and an Invitation

The right publishing path is the one that aligns with your goals, your budget, and the level of support you want. The purpose of this guide is not to push you toward any single option, but to help you make a clear, informed decision. If this guide helps you ask better questions and avoid costly mistakes, then it has done its job.

If you would like a second set of eyes on your publishing options, True Haven Press offers a free consultation to help authors think through where their manuscript fits, what support they may need, and whether hybrid publishing makes sense for their goals. There is no obligation—just a chance to ask questions and get clarity before you move forward.

A FREE CONSULTATION

Talk it through with True Haven Press

Bring your questions, your manuscript, and your goals. We'll help you think through where your book fits—no obligation, no pressure.

[Book Your Free Consultation](#)



Transparent ~ Reliable ~ Unwavering ~ Excellence

Debra L Hartmann
Chief Publishing Officer & Managing Editor
debra@truehavenpress.com
1 800-585-3690